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New Trump rules passed by Congress last year cap the amount students who pursue some advanced degrees, from teaching to social work, can borrow for graduate work to **\$100,000**,

but it may not be enough to cover the cost of education

A new ceiling on career ladder?



SUZANNE KREITER/
GLOBE STAFF

Siobhan Deasy instructed student nurses at the MGH Institute of Health Professions.



One in 10 nursing jobs in Massachusetts is vacant and **82%** of nursing students nationally believe the loan limits will make it harder to finance graduate education.

Caps on graduate loans could aggravate shortage of nurses, other critical roles

By Diti Kohli and Mara Kardas-Nelson
GLOBE STAFF

Abena Binfaah, an undergraduate nursing student at Boston College, is excited to join the workforce after she graduates in May.

“I like to help people, to care for others,” Binfaah said. “With nursing, there’s a variety of things you can do. There’s room to grow.”

Binfaah had already been plotting how to advance her nascent career: She plans to move back in with her family to save money, work for a few years, then return to school to get a graduate degree as a nurse practitioner,

a position that has become more critical for patients amid the stubborn shortage of primary care doctors.

Now, though, Binfaah is reconsidering. New rules passed by Congress last summer as part of President Trump’s signature tax legislation cap what Binfaah and students who pursue some advanced degrees, from teaching to social work, can borrow for graduate work to \$100,000. That, she said, is not enough to pay for graduate school.

“I come from a low-income background. I’ll have to rely on loans. I don’t think \$100,000 is reasonable,”

NURSES, Page A13

A star’s meltdown is fodder for a farcical return to the stage

By Mark Shanahan
GLOBE STAFF

It was supposed to be a Hollywood star’s triumphant return to Broadway.

But when legendary — and legendarily prickly — actress Faye Dunaway slapped a crew member backstage before a show in Boston in 2019, the comeback was over before it began.

Dunaway, who was set to perform on Broadway for the first time in more than three decades, was abruptly fired from Matthew Lombardo’s one-woman show “Tea at Five.” Her sudden dismissal, announced by producers in a two-sentence press release just as the show’s pre-Broadway run at the Huntington Theatre in Boston was ending, extinguished any hope the playwright had of taking the production to New York.

“It was heartbreaking for all of us — for me, the designers, the staff, the crew, and especially for Faye,” Lombardo said. “The way it ended was a heartbreak.”

PLAY, Page A13



‘When you put a force like that into a fragile, developing, theatrical ecosystem, things can get combustible.’

MATTHEW LOMBARDO, on his experience working with Faye Dunaway

Boston liquor permits finally flowing freely

After multiple tries, new free licenses spark a creative menu of options

By Shirley Leung
GLOBE STAFF

A free liquor license has been a financial lifeline for Biplaw Rai and Nyacko Pearl Perry, helping to make Dorchester’s Comfort Kitchen into the darling of Boston’s restaurant scene, complete with a James Beard nomination.

Now the city has given the husband-and-wife team another free license as they prepare to open Ama at The Atlas in Allston this month. Free is key. If their only option was to buy a license for a half-million dollars, they’d have struggled to come up with the money to run a full bar in Boston.

“This is like winning the lottery,” said Rai.

When Rai and Perry opened Comfort Kitchen in 2023, the city had just about run out of free licenses unless another restaurant returned theirs. The couple was lucky to get one, and they learned just how much their bottom line depended on beer, wine, and cocktails: Alcohol can be twice as profitable as food.

“Without a liquor license,” Rai added, “we would not have survived.”

Rai and Perry got lucky again when groundbreaking legislation in 2024 created 225 new liquor licenses for Boston. Suddenly, the city finds itself flush with licenses in what could be the biggest expansion of alcoholic permits since

LIQUOR LICENSES, Page A14

64 new liquor licenses awarded	
Dorchester	14
East Boston	11
Jamaica Plain	10
Roslindale	6
Roxbury	5
South End	5
Oak Square	3
Hyde Park	3
Allston	2
Charlestown	1
Downtown	1
Fenway	1
Mission Hill	1
Mattapan	1

SOURCE: Boston Licensing Board



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Owner Maya Mukhopadhaya poured a glass at **Jadu Cafe and Wine Bar** in Jamaica Plain. A liquor license has allowed it to be a vibrant spot at night.

Senators splitting on primary picks

Democrats part over insider vs. outsider tactic

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

On paper, the invitation to the event was nothing special: an incumbent senator hosting a fund-raiser in Washington for a candidate hoping to win a Senate race that is central to their party’s hopes this election year.

But New Mexico Senator Martin Heinrich’s decision to hold an event last month for Graham Platner, the upstart progressive competing in a primary against establishment favorite Governor Janet Mills in Maine, raised eye-

brows in political circles in part because it epitomized a fresh — and fraught — dynamic on display in the 2026 election cycle.

In contentious primaries in Maine, Michigan, and Minnesota — all must-win states for the party this year — Democratic senators are increasingly endorsing competing candidates and, in the process, lining up behind competing visions of how the party can win back majorities and rebuild the brand in 2026.

Given the often-delicate personal and political dynamics of the upper chamber, the emerging trend is a stark departure from previous election cycles, in which senators

DEMOCRATS, Page A12

Big one for Patriots

New England’s amazing season will be on the line this afternoon at 3 as they face the Houston Texans in a divisional round playoff game in Foxborough. **C1.**

Flake, punt

Sunday: A little snow. High 35-40. Low 23-28.
Monday: Sun returns. High 33-38. Low 20-25.
High tide: 10:46 a.m., 11:24 p.m.
Sunrise: 7:09 Sunset: 4:40

Complete report, C24.

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\$6.00

President Trump announced his latest strategy to get control of Greenland: He is slapping new tariffs on a bloc of nations. **A2.**

At 25, Wikipedia is more important than ever — and more vulnerable. **Ideas, K1.**

It’s January but there’s still plenty to see and do. Check out the Winter Arts Guide. **N1.**



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